



VP Engineering & AI

Big Viking Games | Toronto, ON (Hybrid — 4 days/week in-office, Queens Quay West)

About Us

Big Viking Games is a profitable, self-funded live-service games studio based in Toronto. Founded in 2011, we've built and operated virtual worlds serving millions of players through deep in-game economies, player-to-player trading, and long-term engagement.

Our founder-CEO has returned to refound the company as an AI-first live-operations games company. Significant investment is committed, stealth AI platforms are in build, and 2.0 products are underway on existing franchises. We operate with the speed and conviction of a startup, backed by the stability of a proven, revenue-generating business.

This is not the outside-in view of a legacy social games studio. This is a rebuild.

The Role

We are hiring a VP Engineering & AI to lead the technical transformation of BVG, the engineering organization, the architecture, the development practices, and the AI infrastructure — while keeping our live titles running and generating revenue.

You will own the technical roadmap for AI/ML capabilities, game and backend architecture, engineering standards, and infrastructure across the entire portfolio. You are responsible for building the technical foundation for what comes next.

This role sits at the intersection of three things:

1. **Applied AI in production.** Not research. Not strategy decks. You have personally built AI systems that run in production, and you will build more here — agentic content pipelines, intelligent game systems, AI-native player experiences, and the infrastructure to support all of it.
2. **Live-service game engineering.** You know what it means to keep a game running 24/7 with real players and real revenue while simultaneously rebuilding the plane in flight. You have shipped free-to-play games and operated them at scale.

3. **Engineering leadership through transformation.** You are inheriting a team of 18+ developers across multiple titles and platforms. You will assess, restructure, and level up this organization — not incrementally, but as a refounding. You've done this before in at least one prior role.

The mix is roughly 20–30% player / 70–80% coach. You must be deeply technical — credible in architecture conversations, able to evaluate AI systems hands-on, capable of unblocking hard problems personally. But the primary job is leading, coaching, and rebuilding an engineering organization.

What You'll Own

AI Transformation & Agentic Systems

- Architect and build agentic systems for automated game content production — art, items, events, narrative — and live-ops workflows
- Lead implementation of AI-native features across our games: intelligent NPCs, dynamic in-game interactions, AI-assisted moderation, real-time player personalization
- Design and build scalable data pipelines integrating player behaviour, social graphs, CRM data, and game telemetry to power AI-driven decisions across live ops, monetization, and retention
- Build context engineering systems and infrastructure to enable agentic automation across both internal studio operations and live game environments
- Drive adoption of AI tooling and workflows across engineering, game design, art, product, and live-ops — this is an organization-wide transformation, not an engineering silo
- Own the technical roadmap for AI/ML capabilities supporting current titles (YoWorld, FishWorld) and the 2.0 game platform

Engineering Organization & Leadership

- Serve as a key member of the senior leadership team, translating technical capabilities into business and product strategy
- Inherit and restructure the engineering organization — assess talent, redefine roles and team topology, and build the org structure needed for the 2.0 era
- Hire, mentor, and develop engineering talent, building technical capabilities across the studio
- Establish engineering standards, workflows, and best practices across the full game development lifecycle — from prototyping to live operations
- Drive strategy, architecture, and adoption of AI-enabled software development practices across the engineering organization
- Own engineering budget priorities and investment trade-offs aligned with studio and game-level goals
- Evaluate and manage third-party technology partnerships, game tech vendors, middleware, and build-vs-buy decisions
- Prepare and present technical updates to the CEO and Board, including roadmap progress, risks, and trade-offs

Live-Service Infrastructure & Reliability

- Provide technical direction for client (Unity) and backend game services teams
- Own cloud infrastructure strategy, cost optimization, and scaling decisions for live game services
- Ensure live-service reliability, security posture, anti-cheat and fraud controls, and incident management practices

- Elevate DevOps and SRE maturity including build pipelines, deployment automation, observability, and infrastructure-as-code
- Collaborate with data and analytics teams on game telemetry, instrumentation, and player analytics infrastructure

What You Bring

Must-Haves

- **15+ years of software engineering experience** with 5+ years in senior technical leadership. You have lived through multiple platform shifts — Flash to mobile, web to native, monolith to microservices, pre-AI to AI-native — and have the pattern recognition that only comes from reps
- **Deeply technical career path.** You rose to Staff or Principal Engineer before moving into management, or you were a hands-on startup CTO who shipped production systems personally. If you became a manager early and have spent most of your career in people management without staying technical, this is not the role
- **Shipped free-to-play games in a live-service environment.** This is non-negotiable. You must have multi-platform exposure and understand virtual economies, player engagement loops, and live-ops cadence. A brilliant AI leader from fintech or SaaS who has never shipped a game will not succeed here — the domain complexity is too high and the ramp too long for a role that needs to deliver immediately
- **Applied AI/ML expertise with production systems.** You have personally built AI systems running in production — not POCs, not hackathons, not strategy presentations. You can speak to specific implementations, trade-offs, and hard problems you solved hands-on
- **Personal use of agentic AI coding tools.** You use Claude Code (or equivalent) in your own work and have been doing so for 6+ months. If you're not already working this way, you're behind the curve for this role
- **Led engineering organizations of 20+ people.** Ideally you have experience in larger orgs (60+) and have personally restructured or refactored engineering teams. You know how to assess talent, redesign team topology, and build an org that operates differently than the one you inherited
- **Strong architectural thinking** across backend systems, data pipelines, AI infrastructure, and game services
- **Proven ability to ship and operate live products at scale** with high reliability and performance requirements

The Profile We're Looking For

- **Inventor mindset.** You hack on bleeding-edge technology on the side regardless of what your day job demands. You are innately curious, always experimenting, always pulling the organization forward on technology rather than being pulled
- **Venture-ecosystem DNA.** Your career has gravitated toward startups, scale-ups, and venture-backed companies. You understand what it means to operate with speed, conviction, and resource constraints. Careers spent entirely in large enterprise, consulting, or banking are not the right background
- **Transformation framing.** You see AI as an opportunity to invent a new way to operate — an organizational and operational architecture problem, not a labor problem. If your instinct is to frame AI adoption as "reduce headcount" or "add tools to existing workflows," this role is not for you. The mandate is to reimagine how a games studio builds, operates, and delivers

Nice-to-Haves

- Hands-on experience building and shipping games on Unity (or directly comparable real-time game engines)
- Experience with real-time or interactive application frameworks
- Background in consumer products with large-scale daily active user bases
- Consumer internet and/or consumer mobile experience
- Familiarity with platform economics, user segmentation, and monetization systems
- Track record of building technical infrastructure and platforms from zero

Who You Are

- A builder who defines what gets built — you don't wait for a roadmap, you create it
- Calm and decisive under the pressure of running live systems while rebuilding architecture
- Deeply technical but not precious about code — you know when to architect and when to delegate
- Comfortable inheriting complexity and bringing order without breaking what's working
- A leader engineers want to work for — you attract and retain strong technical talent
- Relentlessly curious about what's possible and impatient about getting there

Why This Role

This is a rare opportunity to shape the technical direction of a profitable, scaled live-service studio at the exact moment AI is rewriting what's possible in game development.

You will have the autonomy to make big bets, the resources to execute, and a CEO who is deeply technical and fully committed to the AI-first rebuild. You are not being hired to maintain what exists. You are being hired to build what comes next.

Benefits

- Comprehensive health and wellness benefits (health, dental, vision) including HSA/WSA spending account from Day One
- Participation in the Employee Stock Option Plan (ESOP)
- RRSP participation and matching
- 15 Vacation Days + 10 Wellness Days

Big Viking Games is committed to creating an inclusive and accessible environment for all candidates. We welcome applications from individuals of all abilities and will provide accommodations throughout the hiring process as needed. If you require any accommodations, please email hr@bigvikinggames.com.